

miracles – nearly every religion on the face of this planet has a few to their credit that hold believers in sway. The wonders and miracles of Dataism is going to be a lot more individualised and personal, therefore more convincing to believers of its cause. Let's explain this further.

All this while we believed that 'feelings' were spiritual in nature and humanity had to thank religion to help us tune into what our heart desired. But feelings aren't necessarily the opposite of rational thought, as they're nothing but highly evolved rational thought that comes naturally or without expending a lot of effort. For example, when a deer, buffalo or human is confronted by a deadly wild predator, the feeling of fear as a response is generated by capturing visual data and biochemical algorithms processing it to calculate the probability of survival. In the same way, feeling of sexual attraction between two people arises when biochemical algorithms in our brain, based on visual data, calculate the probability of a high chance of successful copulation. In short, feelings aren't spiritual, just highly evolved biochemical algorithms over millions of years of evolution. We certainly don't have religion to thank for it.

This is where things become really tricky with Dataism. Because if feelings aren't spiritual in nature, then so is the concept of 'free will'. Everything mystical or spiritual about our brain's (yes, brain, no hearts don't make decisions based on feeling) ability to make decisions is based on purely age old biochemical algorithms perfected over millions of years of accumulating and interpreting data (thanks to evolu-

tion). And up until now, our desires and choices were only known to us, whether we were religious or not. Religious authority dictated how we should live our lives but lacked the tools and data to get an insight into our personal biochemistry to accurately ascertain the intangible thoughts and feelings germinating inside of us. From the outside you could be a Hindu to everyone else, but no Hindu authority could tap into your brain to see if you always had pious thoughts or led your life in accordance with scripture.

But where religion failed, Dataism will prevail.

Thanks to advances in medical science and the explosion of data-computing power, our thoughts and decisions may not wholly belong to us in the future. Medical frontiers are being broken every year and we're closer to understanding how the brain functions, how thoughts are formed, what influences them and the biochemical process that conducts this subliminal physiological orchestra inside our body. Pair that with massively complex data systems – the future of IoT where multiple systems seamlessly exchange data with one another – tracking your every move online and vitals like heart rate, perspiration rate, pupil dilation, and more.

At the confluence of these two breakthroughs in human medicine and unprecedented compute-power, we will be constantly tracked and analyzed, generating big data on a truly epic scale. Algorithmically-driven digital systems, thanks to advancements in machine learning and artificial intelligence, will at this point more know about you than you know yourself.

RECOMMENDED READING:

While researching for this article, the author came across two seminal books on the topic that makes you think. If you liked this article and want to know about how all-consuming data is shaping our impending future then give Steve Lohr's *Data-ism* a read (<http://dgit.in/Dataism>). Also don't miss Yuval Noah Harari's *Homo Deus: A Brief History of Tomorrow* (<http://dgit.in/HomoDeus>). Truly insightful and thought-provoking.

They'll know our feelings much better than we could ever hope to know. That process has already begun. If you read a few books on Kindle, Amazon knows exactly what genres excite you and where you stop reading books, to push you towards what you're most likely to buy. The constant unravelling of the human genome has led doctors to understand terminal disease causing genes – if it's present in someone, preventive measures to prolong life can kick in much much earlier than before. Google's tracking you all the time through your emails and search history, so is Facebook through its global social network, and every other global Internet-based business.

We create and share data willingly, and yet – in a not so distant future – the very thing that makes us human will be consumed by data itself. Data is the key that will rid us of our human condition. Maybe it won't be so bad after all, if it means our species progresses to embrace its cosmic destiny. **d**

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